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EDITORIAL



Adoring Shankara as arising from the mystic configuration of his own Shakti

In his gloss on the first canto of the *spandkarika* - the commentator makes obeisance to Shankara who is signified by the splendour of the configuration of his Shaktis. The real Shiva in his essential nature who is omnipotent to carry out all the five functions, springs forth from his unison with his own Shaktis. The absolute one doesn't have to immerse from anywhere since all his shakti unifies and then remains assimilated in him as inseparable. This, as the agamic canons put it, never enters the category of मेय so no question of any obeisance being made to him arises. One Shakti indistinguishable from Shiva expresses herself in variegated manifestation to display her grandeur. Unlike one devout poet who out of sheer affection for Shiva says, "O shambhu you are a mendicant and have nothing so what can you give me, just give me an unswerving devotion of your feet." The philosopher of deep philosophic ingenuity says, "without your mediating Shakti ask her splendour, there is no duality so there can be no obeisance." No one can salute himself or thump his own back i.e. in a metaphysical way. This school of sphurattavsada or the spasmodic projection of awareness developed as a rejection of dire negation of anything except the absolute principle and also as a refutation of the total absence of substantiality in any form. Both belong to ages old philosophical rivals Shankarite monism and the Buddhist theory of nothingness. Nevertheless, both have their own justifications for explaining the universal phenomena, the former calls it vyavahariki and *pratibhasiki* state [transitory assumption] of an illusory entity as true or an acceptance of virtual truth of inexistent entities whereas the notion of *abhutparikalpa* [conceptualising what was never actually generated]. The doctrine of Spanda delivered an aspirant from the tyranny of absolute nothingness and illusoriness. The secondary manifestation named by the author of Bhamati as *dwitaya sachiv parampara* or the trail of secondary and thus conditioned manifestation of the absolute. This is as it were somewhere near to this concept of projection of consciousness or to be more precise, the power of consciousness in the form of the universal phenomena consisting of interlaced word and meaning in the form of thirty-six elements and as many syllables of Sanskrit language en rapport with their corresponding tatwas, the elementary constituents of the phenomena.

This Shakti and her projections of consciousness are like a mirror in which Shiva, the absolute, reflects and cognises his shivahood. Devotion and its expression-obeisance or prostrations is absorption according to the Shiva doctrine. The Sanskrit term for this is *samavesh*.

Assimilation or absorption. the intuitive insight into one's own essential nature i.e shivahood is *namahh* or prostration. The *root nu* means bowing down as well as

The only way an adept bows down to Shiva is by seeking unison with him and the only way of psalmodising is by transcending all expressions audible as well conceptual. The orb of Shiva's shakti from which his cognisable manifestation incarnates is an expression of his munificence which enables all अणु - the empirical experiencers to trace their way back to their essential nature by optimising subjective awareness and minimising and finally eliminating all objectivity. Needless to say that even a bounded pashu is also the absolute parameshwar playing the role of a pashu. The strenuous and at times impracticable discipline of the conventional doctrines are rendered practicable and agreeable simultaneously in the path of the agamas.

Swami Paranand Tirth

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Mount Kailash in the Kalachakra Tantra

The importance of Mt. Kailash for Hindu, Buddhists, Jain and Bon religion is immense. In the Kalachakra Tantra, Mt. Kailash region is seen as the ultimate sacred site for the end of the dharmic journey of mankind. The importance of the Kalachakra Tantra in Asian history remains fully unexplored. This Tantra influenced Mongol court, more particularly the wife and son of Kublai Khan himself. In the beginning of the last century, this Tantra echoed as far as St. Petersburg and Hangzhou. While a Kalachakra Temple was constructed in St. Petersburg (1915) under the patronship of the last Russian Czar to fulfil the prophetic visions of the 13th Dalai Lama. Chinese nationalists organized a huge public ceremony of Kalachakra mandala for world peace in Forbidden City, Beijing in October 1932, with a belief to ward off Japanese aggression.

The Kalachakra Tantra was composed during the first half of the 11th century. It was a world war kind of situation in Eurasia. Chola kings attacked the Srivijaya empire in Southeast Asia. Islamic invasion had wiped out all the Buddhist outposts in Central Asia and knocked down Indian kings one by one. The composer had an apocalyptic vision for the world. The war between noble people (Arya) and mleccha (wicked) people was prophesied. The last Kalki King, the Raudra Kalki was prophesied to come from the land of Shambhala and after defeating the barbarians, he would reign for 50 years before departing to the city designed by gods located behind Mt. Kailash i.e. north of Kailash.

Kailash is different from Meru and Shambhala. Meru is the central axle of the cakravaal system; Kailash is one of the sections of the Greater Jambudvipa in which Mt. Kailash, the best of the snow mountains is situated. Shambhala is a Vishaya (विषय) – a region in the section of Kailash, but not around Mount Kailash per se.

Meru finds first mention at verse 10 of the first chapter. It is 1 lakh or 0.1 million yojana in height. 1 yojana is equal to 3200 arm-length (hasta). If one considers arm-length at 40 cm, then 1 yojana will be around 13 km. Thus, the height of Meru is assumed to be 1.3 million km, or almost 4 times the distance of the moon from the earth. Tantra mentions that at 25000 yojana, the planets revolve around Meru. In actuality the orbit of the moon lies at that height. The external universe is stated to have a measure of 4 lakh (0.4 million) yojana. The ratio of circumference and diameter, though is π , is assumed for approximation at value of 3. Then, the circumference of the outer ring of the external universe is 12 lakh yojana. On the surface of the earth, a set of 6 mountains, 6 continents and 6 oceans are arranged around Meru like a girdle. These 18 structures have a combined width of 16000 yojana. Each structure has a width of 111, less than 1000 or 889 yojana. Corresponding with this number are 889 major channels inside the body. There are 10 principal nadis, 156 chakra nadis in the 6 chakras, 360 nadis at 12 bodily joints also known as karma chakra and 360 nadis at 60 knuckles of fingers and toes (6 at each knuckle, a nadi each for one of the six elements i.e. earth, water, fire, wind, space and gnosis), then there are 3 downward flowing channel for urination, defecation, dissemination.

The earliest mention of Mt. Kailash in the Kalachakra Tantra is in the Vimalprabha commentary on verse 54 of the first chapter. This commentary was composed by Kalki Pundarika during the 11th century. The maximum variation in duration of day and night at Kailash is 10 nadis or 4 hours. There are 60 nadis in a day and night. This approximates the modern scientific measurement of 4 hours 40 minutes at Mt Kailash.

The 54th verse of the first chapter of the Tantra mentions Mt. Kailash for the first time. It is with regard to the sun's northward movement. The major description of the Mt. Kailash is in the 'Kalki' section of the first chapter. The 149th verse mentions that the seventh continent is the Jambudvipa. We have discussed the set of 6 continents, 6 mountains and

6 oceans around Meru. This Jambudvipa is then encircled by the seventh ocean- ocean of salt-water.

The Jambudvipa is the land of karma while other inner continents are the land of *bhoga*, i.e. enjoyment.

The width of the Jambudvipa ring is 25000 yojana. The outer periphery is 3 lakh yojana. It has 12 sections. Then, each section has an outer periphery of 25000 yojana. One of the sections has Mt. Kailash. This is named the Kailash Khanda. Other 11 sections have not been named in the Tantra.

Mt. Kailash is surrounded (वेष्टितः) from all sides and is the best of Snow Mountains.

Interestingly, this section also mentions the land of Shambhala which is surrounded by the mountains from all sides. There is no mention of snow-capped mountains in Shambhala. This also indicates that Shambhala is close to the tropics, rather than the Arctic. The next verse mentions the Kailash section which has Mt. Kailash, which has three equal divisions.

Outside of each petal, there are 12 countries. On the right half (सव्यार्धे) Shambhala is known, where the best of sages reside. In Sambhala there are 10 million villages. Thus in each vishaya, there are 10 million villages and in the mandala, there are one lakh villages. These are the terms used for administrative division in post-Gupta Bengal. Thus within each Khanda (खण्ड), i.e., section; there are 96 vishayas; then within each vishaya, there are 100 mandalas. Within each mandala there are 1 lakh villages. The arrangement of eight petals containing 12 regions each in the Kailash section of Jambudvipa has been mentioned. Shambhala is on the right side, i.e., south. Thus Shambhala is not towards the Arctic north; but very much in the tropical region.

Here is a wider depiction of the seventh continent, i.e., Jambudvipa. There are 1152 vishyas. Total count of villages will go to 1152 koti (कोटि) or 11520 million. This will be 11.52 billion. Such a huge number of villages appear bombastic and outlandish. But, assuming people in place of villages; we get the total population of the seventh continent i.e. the land of karma at 11.52 billion; surprisingly the recent UN peak population projection for the world is 11 billion by 2100 AD.

Let us look at modern geography with a Kalachakran perspective. We can see the world in an eight petal view. Russia-Siberia, north of Mongolia can be seen as a separate division. Europe can be seen as another petal. North America, South America, sub-Saharan Africa, Australia, Greenland and Asia similarly, can be seen as other petals. Asia includes Horn of Africa since the Fatimids in Cairo, Egypt and adjacent Christian civilization in the horn of Africa i.e. Makuria and Alodia, have been viewed as part of Kailash Khanda in the Tantra.

Thence, also Asia-petal of the Kailash section can further be seen as comprising 12 major kingdoms extant during the first half of the 11th century when the Kalachakra Tantra text was composed. These are Arya, China, Mahachina, Tibet, Persia, Ruhya (Egypt), Surasma (Makuria & Alodia), Mecca, Campa, Shambhala, Sinhala, and Suvarnadvipa. I have placed Shambhala and Sinhala in close proximity. The Tantra further mentions that at the end of the battle of civilization in which the wicked forces world be destroyed; the great Kalki King would go to the city around Mt. Kailash. Again the next couple of verses reiterates how Kalki would go to the city designed by Gods themselves. Mt. Kailash further finds mention in the second chapter of the Tantra. Verse 49 mentions the offering of dharma at Mt. Kailash eradicates the fear of cyclic existence.

Kalki is seen as the sovereign of the whole chakra of the Jambudvipa. Kalki is always in the front section where he helps eliminate the barbaric tendencies and establishes the supremacy of dharma. Kalki though belongs to Shambhala, he departs for the special

super-smart city designed by gods around Mt. Kailash. The description is based solely on the Sanskrit text of the Kalachakra Tantra. The importance of Mt. Kailash can be gleaned from the fact that it is much more than Shambhala.

Whereas Shambhala is a land of peace, delight and abundance; Kailash is where the virtues are propagated. It is the regenerative womb of Dharma. Salutation to Kailash! Salutation to Masters and Siddhas!

(Part of presentation made on 27 March 2022 during the Fifth International Conference on the Phenomenon of the Holy Mt. Kailash organized by Hamburg University, Germany)

[Shri Niraj Kumar is the author of pentalogy on Kalachakra Tantra. The first volume has recently been published by DK Printworld under the title, “The Kalachakra Tantra: Translation, Annotation & Commentary, Vol. I(2022)].

Aadi Shankaracharya Srividya and Brahavidya

Prof. Satheesha K. S.

India is the Centre of Spirituality. *Rishies* and hermits through *Mantra - Darshana* have gained this knowledge that *Jeevatama* is *Sacchidananda Advaita Brahma* only. A *Sadhaka* who is spiritually inclined has *Bhakti, Shravana, Manana* and *Nidhidhyasana* will automatically merge with *Paramatattva*. The Indian *Shashtra* tradition is a Beam of light for this fact. *Bhagavatpada Shankaracharya* has revealed *Advaitatattva* through *Prasthantraya Bhasya, Prakaran, Prabandha* and *Stotra* along with reviving all *Sampradaya* for the promotion and protection of these *Shashtra*. *Vidhyaranyayati's* words also clear these facts - सम्प्रदायो हि न अन्योऽस्ति श्रीशंकराद्वहिः¹

The literary works of *Acharya Bhagwatpada* are equally useful and relevant for all classes and community. For the *Mumukshu* these *Bhashya, Prabandha, Prakarana* and *Stotra* are to pave way for *Moksha*. To assume that *Bhashya* is for highly evolved people, *Prakarana* is for moderately evolved people and *Stotra* etc., is for average people, does not seem right reason being that sometimes. A *Sadhaka* will get attracted towards abstruse matter and sometimes will simply achieve *Paramatattva* through Devotion only. Thus it is safe to say that every individual of the society would equally benefit by all writings of *Shankaracharya*.

Saundaryalahari and *Prapanchasara* of *Bhagavatpada* have a significant value in *Tantragama Shashtra*. *Bhagavatpada* has established unity of Indian culture through the content of *Shriyantra* and *Shrividhya*. *Saundaryalahari* is the most established *Stotra* among all *Bhagavatpada's* works, where we can get the entire essences of *Advaitatattva* as described in *Vedas*, along with the *Srividya upasana*. Upon studying the both *prastanatrayi* and *Soundarya lahari*, it becomes clear that there is no difference between in *Brahmavidhya* and *Shrividhya*. we can have some examples here-

It is stated in *Prashnopanishad* that the world originated from - *Agni vand Soma*. आदित्यो ह वै प्राणो रयरेव चन्द्रमा¹. This is the essence of *Srividya* where it is stated that world originates from *shiva* and *shakti*. Same is stated in *Uma - haimavati* context of *Kenopanishad*² as well.

Bhagavatpada declares in *Soundarya lahari* that Just upon chanting the first to words भवाहन त्वं *sadhaka* is blessed with *Moksha* by *Bhagwati* and it is so potent that it is equivalent to the famous words ‘अं ब्रह्माहति³ from *Upanishad*. From the *saundaryalahari shloka* श्रुतीनां विस्तारः⁴ *Acharya* clarifies that *Jagadamba* is the subject matter of all *Upanishads*. So *Saundaryalahari* and *Upanishads* have the same subject matter of *Paramadvaita* which is *Param Brahma* only.

¹ *Prashnopanishad*- 1/4

² *kenopanishad*- 4/1

³ *Brihadarnyakopnishd*- 1/4/10

⁴ *Saundaryalahari- 84*

It is worth to be noted that in the traditional worship ceremony of *Shrichakra*, Advaita Acharyas are remembered at the beginning -

नारायणं पद्मभुवं वहशष्ठं शक्तं च त्रिपुत्रपराशरं च।

व्यासं शकं गौडपदं त्रिंशद्भिर्गोहवन्दयोगीन्द्रिथातय हशष्टिः। श्रीशंकराचार्याथितय पद्मपादं च
त्रिंशद्विंशतिं च हशष्टिं

त्रिंशत्त्रयं वार्त्तिकं कारित्वान्, अतिद् गुरुन्सन्निहितः॥५॥

Thus it clarifies the fact that although the *Acharyas* of *Shrividya* and *Brahamvidya* may have difference of opinion and follow different path but their final aim was Paramadvaita which is the establishment of *eternal knowledge*.

Each and every shloka from Saundryalahari establishes Advaitvada it self. The unity of all sadhaka, upasya and Srividya is shrichakra. Therein the Midst Goddess Paramshiva shaktisvarupa Mahatripursundri is established.

According to the Five Vedic Sanhitas namely Vasishtha, Sanaka, Sanandan, Shuka and Sanatkumara, Shiva and Shakti have five common elements in them

- *Adhishthana*, *Avstha*, *Anushthana*, *Naam* and *Roop*. This is the basic concept of samayachara. In this context *Samaya* is not restricted to mean specific time but the word *Samaya* is means *Shiva*, *Samayaa* means *Bhagwati Tripursundari* and *Samayi* means *Sadhaka*. The methodology where a *Sadhaka* who has pure *Chitta* is seated in his *Sadhana* in *Nirguna* Paramttava in *Abhedasthiti* is called *Samyachara*, which is also the highest state according to advaita vedantis. Thus, it is believed that the Srividya is prakriya part of advaita. And that is the reason why Adi Shankara bhagavtpada initiated the worship of srichakra in various devi temples in India along with the maths established by himself. some of them as following-

⁵ Sampradayika Shloka

1. **Sharadamba, Shringeri** - In Karnataka Shringeri, *Sharadamba* idol is established on *Shrichakra* in *Dakshinamaya peetha*.



2. **Kanaka-Durga Vijayavada** - In Andhra Pradesh Kanaka-Durga is considered Devi of Power, money and charity. Aadi Shankracharya had stabilised *Shrichakra* there and also started Vedic worship of Kanaka-Durga.



3. **Mahalakshmi, Kohlapur** - Mahalakshmi temple is in Maharashtra. It is said that Aadi Shankracharya revived this very temple and stabilised *Shriyantra*, which is worshiped even today.



4 **Bhramaramba, Shrishailam** - In Andhra Pradesh, Shrishailam Devi temple is established which is dedicated to *Bhramaramba* and *Mallikarjuna*. The main idol is stabilised by Jagatguru Aadi Shankaracharya. He even stabilised the *Shrichakra* there.



Likewise *Meenakshi mandir* was established in Shivasamudram in Karnataka , *Mukambika* in Kollur, *Kamakshi* in Kanchipuram in Tamil Nadu , *Kamakhya* in Guwahati, *Shardabhagavati* in Kashmir and at many more places. *Shriyantra* established by Adishankracharya is worshiped even today.

Pratyabhijna made easy 7

Sutra : Sacheko Dvirupaha Trimayas Chaturatma Sapt Panchak Svabhavah

सचैकोद्विरूपःत्रिमयःचतुरात्मा सप्तपंचकस्वभावः।

Translation: Since the correct knowledge of the self leads to emancipation and the incorrect one to bondage, the real and correct nature of the self must be ascertained completely. Thus the seventh aphorism.

Exposition:

Despite being one he assumes, three, four and thirty-five forms (7 and 5) forms respectively.

Why one?

Shiva Bhattaraka alone is the universal self-one without a second. Because the self-effulgent subjective consciousness cannot be conditioned in time and space and an insentient entity can never be subjectively conscious.

Why twofold?

The prakasha of his own accord accepts contractions in the form of prana etc. becomes the conditioned experient of this experience. In this way, it assumes two forms:

- A) Pure Subjective Consciousness
- B) The experiencer of the conditioned objectivity

The trifurcation explained:

Owing to the three taints (mala) viz. Anava, Mayiya and Karmic, the subjective awareness becomes threefold hence Trimaya.

Four forms:

Owing to grosser manifestations of Shunya, Prana and eight categories of Puryastakam and the Gross body it assumes four-fold forms, hence, Chaturatma

Of the nature of thirty-five elements Siva to Prithvi (presumably Siva and Shakti taken as one).

Another interpretation of seven and five:

Seven elements from Siva to Sakala-Shiva as five Shaktis Jnana, Iccha, Kriya, Chit, and Anand. This universal self can lead to emancipation only if intuitively recognised as mentioned above. Otherwise, it leads to a divergence which culminates in the miseries of samsara or material existence.

Questions

1. Two fold refers to bifurcation

Yes

No

Can't say

2. The same subjective awareness upon getting conditioned assumes two forms: With one she remains pure unconditioned awareness and with another experience

Yes
No
Can't say

3. The three taints are Anav, Mayiya and Kayla

Yes
No
Can't say

4. Explain the two renderings of the phrase Saptpanchakam in detail

(Paranand Swami from YTA Google classroom)

A poem by prof Ambika Talwar.

Prayer: A Walking Seed

~ Ambika Talwar

I sighted a man in bedraggled greys
 unwary wild world-shook
 Out of his mouth a silent stream
 words gazing at plaster peeling off walls
 his ragged passion flaking fine beige dust
 him walking muttering odd lingua poesia
 Passersby became invisible
 while he just kept on wearing out
 his stylish shoes thinking of home
 where trees grow madly in the rain
 while he just kept on searing
 decapitated layers of space filtered with echoes
 while he just kept on humming
 under his breath – serenidade vedrina serenite...
 When a bottle rolled down the alley
 someone carefully moved it away
 fruit stalls shook – a melon rolled
 into this man's lined palms – he held it
 with both his hands and became silent –
 mute as a fruit of globular wonder at our world
 in spite of the dementia of drugs warlords
 ideologues and demagogues

This pristine vision claimed his mind
 he fought it as rancid chorus of flies
 crowding the fruit stall – the seed the seed
 he intoned... the seed...
 Oh he just kept on walking shadowy
 streets where lamps cast its beam
 mottled into the dust of over-walked
 roads marked by soles of shoes sore
 muttering... the seed the seed
 Gawkers with sleep and kohl in their
 eyes glanced at this oddity – mad poet
 in their midst unknown unkempt odd
 familiarity of his ragged robes trailing
 in old forgotten stories, deaths rising as
 nightmarish as a moan from the house of prayer
 when men have forgotten the reason
 Our mad poet kept wandering even as
 peony light lifted a little finger – doing its
 own thing to the sound: ...the seed
 where is the pot to hold sacred seed?

II.

I broke the spell with my scratching pen.
 Of what is this pot made? Show me.
 Lead me to this grand design. Ready!
 So I unravel an old poem and wash it
 Another I place in quarantine – raucous lines.
 To you starving one I shall feed grapes

This tired one needs compassion
 Let me soothe your crinkles – Wait!
 You. You are to be locked up for
 stealing my thoughts. You have now
 been un-poemed. Correct yourself!
 Another crumpled lay at edge of moonlit
 window as if a cry would pierce placid
 stained surface. In its crumpled center
 something hard – I just then unfolded
 its ley-lines without time to uncrease
 crumpled torn pages. My fingers
 grasped – in my hand, I found a seed,
 My existential heart gaped – Is this
 the same seed of the mad poet wandering?
 Did the same moon lose it here?
 I stepped out in dimming darkness
 in sliver of peony light to look
 for this mad poet – wandering somewhere
 amid minarets, broken houses, scattered
 fruit, sore shoe soles, whimsical sad dreams,
 lostness of prayer and lament...
 Labyrinthine city is breaking for new
 story to tell the children being born.
 Prayer is voice of the heart – seed within a seed

Prof Talwar, a noted poetess is a professor of creative arts in the US. Many of her poems show her mystic bent as latent in them. She has borrowed the idea from Jalaluddin Rumi's

pessimistic pathetic reflections. The metaphysical orientation of pain, sufferings and mortification is the underlying streamline of consciousness in this poem)

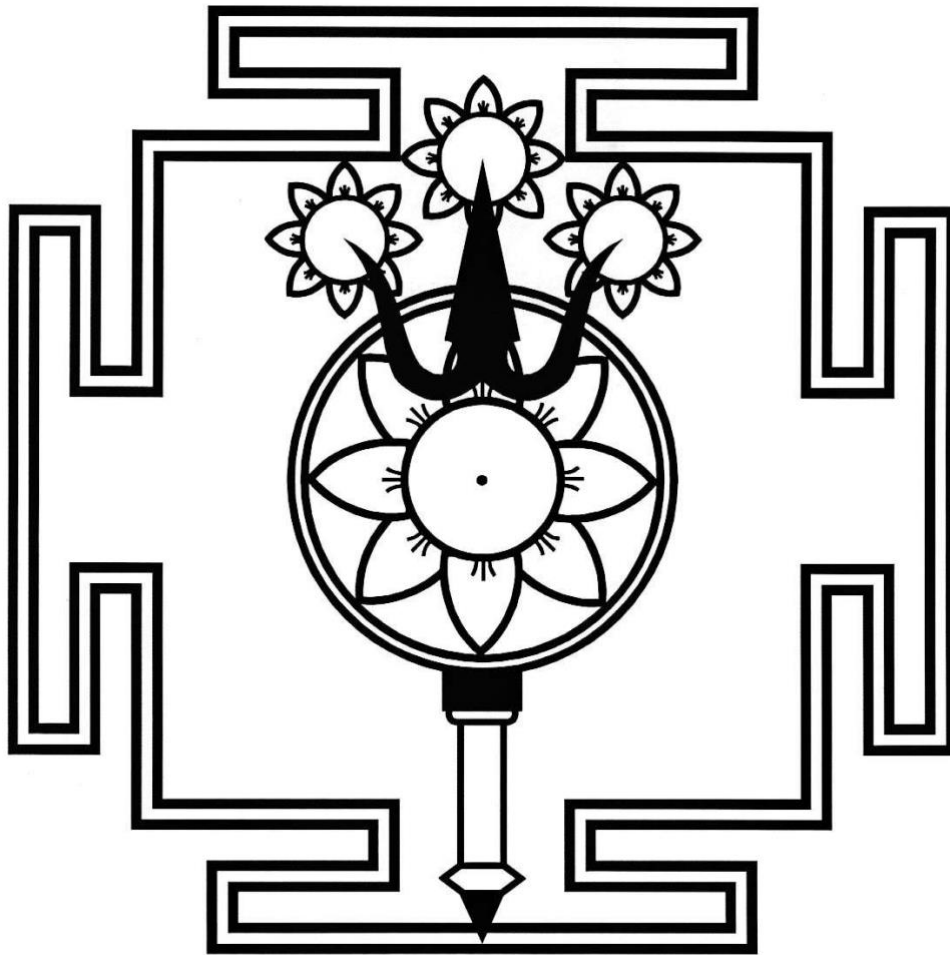
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